

New Cat First Weeks Survival Guide — Action Checklist

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SET UP THE SANCTUARY ROOM

- ❑ **Set Up the Sanctuary Room:** Choose one small room as the sanctuary and stock it with one litter box, one water station, one hiding spot, and the food bowl placed away from each other so your cat feels secure in their territory.
- ❑ **Install the Feliway Diffuser:** Plug a Feliway diffuser into the sanctuary room near the hiding spot to release calming pheromones that help reduce stress-related behaviors and accelerate your cat's adjustment period.
- ❑ **Keep Blinds Closed:** Close all blinds and curtains in the sanctuary room during the first week because outside movement from birds, people, or other cats triggers persistent alertness and prevents your cat from feeling safe enough to explore.
- ❑ **Play Before Bedtime:** Conduct a 15-minute active play session using a wand toy or laser pointer before your bedtime to exhaust your cat's natural hunting instincts so they are ready to rest when you go to sleep.

ESTABLISH THE NIGHTTIME ROUTINE

- ❑ **Move the Final Meal to Nighttime:** Feed your cat their final meal of the day at 10:30pm or 11pm because the combination of digestion and drowsiness naturally aligns with your sleep schedule and prevents the four-hour alertness window that causes nighttime screaming.
- ❑ **Ignore the First 30 Minutes of Crying:** Do not respond to nighttime crying for the first 30 minutes after you go to bed because responding with any attention, even negative responses, reinforces the behavior you are trying to eliminate from your household routine.
- ❑ **Add Environmental Enrichment:** Once your cat is eating and using the litter box reliably, add a cat tree near a window, a second litter box, and interactive toys like paper bags or crumpled balls to provide mental stimulation during the day.
- ❑ **Evaluate Progress by Week Two:** Look for shorter nighttime crying sessions, consistent daytime eating, your cat coming out of hiding when you are in the room, and regular litter box usage as signs that the adjustment is progressing on schedule.

MONITOR PROGRESS AND EXPAND

- ☐ **Call the Vet for Warning Signs:** Contact your veterinarian immediately if your cat strains to urinate or produces only small amounts, goes 24 hours without eating, hides for more than three consecutive days, or shows visible aggression like swatting or hissing.
 - ☐ **Begin Gradual Territory Expansion:** Only after your cat shows consistent eating, regular litter box usage, and reduced nighttime vocalization, open one new room per day beginning with 30-minute supervised exploration sessions before closing the door again.
 - ☐ **Let Your Cat Control the Pace:** Allow your cat to set the speed of territory expansion and do not rush the process because forcing exposure to too much space too quickly increases stress and can restart the hiding and crying cycle.
 - ☐ **Seek Professional Behavior Help:** Contact a veterinary behaviorist if your cat is still screaming for more than two hours every night with no improvement at day 21 because persistent, severe nighttime distress may require specialized intervention beyond standard adjustment protocols.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.